



Big Fish Energy

US – Northeast/NYC

The Premise

If 2026 was about becoming the protagonist of your own hero's journey, then 2027 is about choosing where that story plays out.

Scale has flattened culture. Federal systems feel distant. People are turning inward, investing in small ponds where their voice, taste, and presence actually register.

Big Fish Energy is the shift toward being deeply known in a finite community over being broadly visible to none.

In 2027, mattering somewhere specific beats being seen everywhere.

Why is this important?

People are exhausted by systems that optimize everything while making life feel less stable, less personal, less grounding. AI has compressed discovery into instant gratification, and the byproduct is a culture where everything feels replicable, nothing feels earned, and personal taste has been quietly automated. Federal trust is eroding in ways New Yorkers feel daily. [ICE has arrested more than 9,600 people in the city since January 2025, most without criminal records.](#) The 43-day government shutdown, the longest in US history, [drove flight delays up 467% at New York airports and cost the travel sector \\$6.1 billion.](#) Spirit Airlines collapsed in May 2026, the first major US airline to fold in 25 years. The Trump travel ban expanded from 19 countries to 75 in seven months. [Publications labeled the pattern "travel nightmare,"](#) but staying close became more than logistics. It's an era of yearning — for the past, for physical spaces, for shared experiences that can't be automated. The 2016 revival is everywhere. Analog is emotional infrastructure: listening bars, sober-curious clubs, literary readings pulling rooms across the city. Culture is how people find each other again. Duck libraries appear on Chelsea sidewalks. NYC dating moves from apps to IRL singles events. Concerts turn into immersive worlds — Charli XCX's Brat, Beyoncé's Cowboy Carter, Shrek raves — rituals that only exist if you show up. When the systems above feel unreliable, people don't disengage. They reinvest locally. The smaller the pond, the more meaningful it is to matter in it.

What is the core conflict / opportunity?

The systems today reward scale, but consumers are increasingly craving intimacy, familiarity, and local recognition. That's the tension.

AI, algorithms, and centralized media push culture toward speed and replication. Mass visibility is the default. At the same time, political instability and institutional distrust make people feel detached from the systems running their lives. The result is more visibility, less meaning.

Both ends of the spectrum have real trade-offs. Scale lowers prices and expands access. Local networks can be gatekept, insular, and exclusionary by design. Neither is purely good or bad.

What's clear is where the momentum is heading. People are opting into smaller ecosystems where participation, reputation, and presence carry more weight than broad online attention. Big Fish Energy lives in that opt-in.

Key statistics / quotes / evidence (from within your country)

Collapse of Federal Trust ICE agents deployed at TSA checkpoints landlords weaponizing immigration threats delivery cyclists rising crash rates workers threatening strikes LaGuardia plane crash Zohran Mamdani Effect age played a big role in the NYC mayoral election how design helped Zohran win office of mass engagement YA's drift toward socialism	NYC Community Rebuilding tenants vs. landlords new yorkers get paid \$30/hr to clear snow New Yorkers building snowmen in parks homeownership paths for gig workers Era of Yearning 2016 revival trend yearning slang duck libraries indie sleeze rise of humanities listening bars	Human vs. Machine Friend AI protest NYC scraps new AI high school GLP1 changing consumer behaviors Accenture AI anxiety
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Why did the studio pick this one?

This shift changes how consumers build trust and cultural loyalty. People are becoming more sensitive to experiences that feel generic, mass-produced, or emotionally disconnected from real life.

The future of AI is collaborative, not replacement-driven. The real opportunity is that technology can compress the work so people have more time to build relationships, create culture, and participate in their communities.

Our job as designers is to be AI interpreters. We build the infrastructure and norms that help people use AI intuitively, without the anxiety that their output is slop.

Brands that understand local behavior, emotional needs, and cultural nuance will feel more trustworthy than brands that only optimize for scale and efficiency. The companies that win will make people feel connected, involved, and recognized, not just targeted.

In your roles within Song and DDP, how does it impact your work or your clients?

Universal aesthetics no longer guarantee relevance. Consumers want experiences that feel specific, intentional, and rooted in real communities. The strongest brands will feel less like distant corporations and more like ecosystems people genuinely want to belong to.

For designers:

- Premium on taste:** AI makes technical execution easy. Taste is now the differentiator. Designers who cultivate and defend a clear point of view will lead the next era.
- Era of yearning:** Across generations, people are looking backward — older ones nostalgic for a moment before everything got optimized, younger ones anemoic for a past they never lived. Both want design that feels made by someone for someone. Visible craft, imperfection, specificity, and warmth answer a real emotional need.
- AI for good:** The question is no longer whether to use AI, but how. The opportunity is not to flood the global pond with more noise. It's to use AI to strengthen smaller, trust-rich communities.

For clients

- Redefining legitimacy:** The companies gaining real traction aren't the ones with the biggest reach. They're the ones embedded in real communities. Local partnerships, cultural participation, and consistent presence matter more than mass reach.
- Community building as strategy:** This is a trust strategy, not a marketing ploy. Brands that give people a meaningful role build deeper loyalty than brands still optimizing only for scale.

Proof of Personhood

US – Northeast/NYC

The Premise

As influencers, algorithms, and an exponential increase of AI usage floods our digital spaces with unreliable, synthetic content, it has become **increasingly difficult to distinguish what is real** from what is not. Now, people are **seeking authentic experiences** marked with the human touch, indicated by imperfection and creativity. This trend is a pivot towards prioritizing more **physical presence and unfiltered moments** as we re-discover that that being messy, manual, and real serve as the ultimate proof that life is truly being lived.

Why is this important?

This is a continuation of a desire for transparency and authenticity, and a reassertion of human control amid growing automation. Being trendy on social media and digital platforms isn't disappearing; instead, it serves as springboards for exploring tangible, real-world experiences. People who discovered the same thing online then find each other in the real world and connect IRL. People shape their own experiences around what carries genuine personal significance.

What is the core conflict / opportunity?

The proposition of AI and related technologies has always been to solve problems and improve our QoL. Digital spaces continue to serve as connection points across cultures and communities, removing barriers.

However, even as AI improves in its capabilities, there is still a fundamental, deep-seeded deep distrust and rejection of AI that has not been resolved from the perspective of consumers.

These two tensions will continue to exist and is something that we need to navigate thoughtfully to keep consumer trust in the experiences we design. Leaning into human experience and being mindful of when we engage them and how we suggest utilizing AI can help us to walk this line with them.

Key statistics / quotes / evidence (from within your country)

- **Art and Human Craft:** [W/26-27 Catwalk Trends: Human Craft vs AI Fashion](#) [Boston Public Library launches printmaking workshops to foster community](#) [An artist spent a whole week bed-rotting in a public NYC gallery](#)
- **Community Organization:** [Duck libraries popping up in NYC are sparking a trend of joy for kids](#) [Literary events and pursuits have become very popular in NYC](#) [NYS Fair adds Shrek-themed dance party to 2026 concert lineup](#)
- **Human Connections:** [Boston is tackling the loneliness epidemic by helping people make friends](#) [Conversation and companionship fight loneliness for older New Yorkers](#) [Wrestling speed dating: A unique Valentine's Day in Brooklyn](#) [NYC singles ditch dating apps for new 'Love Is Blind' style IRL event](#) [This Somerville matchmaker has Boston's dating scene down to a science](#)
- **Protest and political engagement:** [Boston May Day protest: Live stream updates](#) [Eight companies explore dance as protest in 'The Politics of Movement'](#) [Ice national shutdown protests expected NYC](#) [Boston No Kings protest march](#)
- **AI Pushback:** [StopFriend Advocates, educators warn NYC students could be at risk under new AI school guidelines](#) [Brooklyn mental health leaders explore how AI is shaping loneliness](#) [New research shows consumers prefer a 'Human' AI persona](#)

Why did the studio pick this one?

This trend is likely not limited to NYC / Boston; however, we represent two very emotional and outspoken cities who don't hide their feelings and have active creative communities. Through local fashion, community events, outreach, protest and art, the sentiment of seeking authenticity and connection as part of a community is seen on the streets on a day-to-day basis and expressed openly, even without people necessarily realizing it.

In your roles within Song and DDP, how does it impact your work or your clients?

As designers and strategists, our work has always been to protect user autonomy and guiding our clients to do the same. Highlighting human craft and expertise that an algorithm can't replicate can help move a client's products beyond transparency to demonstrating sincerity that consumers will respond to. We should help our clients reinforce interactions that aren't just about transaction but meets the customer's emotional needs of security and reassurance to a meaningful relationship with their customers.

Baller Engineers Falling into Precarity

USA West

The Premise

While the top US tech companies are still financially healthy the heyday for the average bay area tech worker at mid career and entry level has gone from baller to precarious.

Entry level workers who used to get signing bonuses and good benefits are more likely now to be a contract employee at the same company with no benefits and a need for renewal every 6months. Mid tier level have increased internal programming tests and built in lay-off cycles. And seed funding for anything other than core AI engineering needs tangible proof of return before getting funded.

Why is this important?

CS is no longer a secure major.

Upper middle-class people in CA are increasing living off stock options and not having children.

Large funding at very amazing bonuses were given to an elite group, now astronomical bonuses and funding are given to an even smaller pool of the population and those are in the AI space. **The disparity of wealth is increasing even here, in the inner nexus gold mine of tech.**

Junior hiring effectively froze. CS graduates' unemployment rate hit ~6% in 2024 higher than the overall college-grad average for the first time since tracking began. - Hired's 2023 State of Software Engineers Report:

Meta's "low performer" cuts of February 2025 (~3,600 employees) hit managers disproportionately.

Equity-driven income at a handful of "Magnificent Seven" stocks now drives roughly **10% of all California income-tax withholding**

What is the core conflict / opportunity?

If the average American retirement fun, the general US economy, and even the laid off workers of these companies rely on the stock success for their livelihood, where does that place our loyalty? Will the bets these companies/investors are making on laying off Engineers, and ignoring non-AI projects pay off in the long-term? How will workforce skills shift and where will these CS majors go? **What will the formerly elite high middle class do with their new forced leisure?**

Key statistics / quotes

Full stack engineer with Advanced Math and CS degrees from top universities. “It is bad to say but I used to easily get laid after I told women my job title, now they are like ‘oh you are an engineer, are you worried about getting laid off.’ It is crazy to think this thing I worked hard my whole life to learn might just be gone. Luckily, I made so much money on stock options from my last job.”

Engineering manager who quit 4 jobs in the last decade because he felt like it and used to receive gifts in the mail to go back to work, “ I studied hard. There were so many rounds of interviews. I didn’t think I was going to get it. My job is basically to have my engineers train AI to do their jobs. And this is the metrics for my performance review.”

Designer on a low code/no code internal enterprise tool “My whole team was cut even though we made money and competitors used our tool. If we were a small company, we would have stayed in business but they want all the engineers working on AI. I think I will be unemployed for a while. I didn’t make money on my income really. I paid off the condo with stock options and bitcoin from 2017.”

Why did the studio pick this one?

Magnificent 7 are the seven dominant, high-performing U.S. technology and growth companies that have significantly outpaced the broader stock market. They also have massive operational footprints and thousands of employees in the Bay Area and have far reaching global implications for the nature and meaning of work and AI. In general, the team felt there is an uneasiness of the future of life and work.

In your roles within Song and DDP, how does it impact your work or your clients?

No comment

AI Media vs Polar Bears : Taste-Washing

USA West

The Premise

Youth feel guilty enjoying AI Media bc of its Environmental Implications. However, they also use AI regularly. Meanwhile tech companies are adopting artisanal aesthetics, fashion, to appear more human, cool, and trustworthy to Gen Z consumers.

Why is this important?

Generative AI is measurably worse for the climate than traditional digital habits. Gen Z knows this (thank God) but is uniquely conflicted bc they use and like AI but are extremely worried about the environment.

73% are "extremely worried" about climate (GlobeScan/BBMG 2024)

62% felt anxious in the past month (Deloitte 2024)

Gen Z is the only cohort where concern about AI's environmental impact spikes. 49% extremely/very concerned vs. 37% of all Americans (Verasight, July 2025).

93% of Gen Z report using AI at work, and the Ghibli-fication trend added a million users to ChatGPT in a single hour. GlobeScan + 3

Chan (2025) in *Education and Information Technologies* validated an AI guilt instrument with three dimensions: perceived laziness/inauthenticity, fear of judgment, and identity/self-efficacy concerns.

What is the core conflict / opportunity?

Ecological Awareness and Anxiety is greater in the youth and spreading.

Psychological Safety

Who, what, where when takes the hit. AI is being used and consumed but in the context of passive enjoyment, entertainment and art it creates more tension.

Brand Trust and Taste-washing aesthetics will have a fine line to walk.

Key statistics / quotes

High school Jr at magnet art school in Texas, “My friends, we don’t really like AI, they actually hate AI. My Dad loves AI.”

SF D&DP in person hang: “I love AI but if I could push a button and make it all go away I would” “Me too, if I could do it for everyone all at once” “me three” “yeah” -4th One abstained.

LA Entertainment Consultant : "AI enhanced faces are making new talent irrelevant, the safest bet long term being an ugly face...Old face is the new hire-able”

Oakland based Comic Artist: “I don’t know what my position is on AI yet. I know I can’t use it in my art or I would lose my fan base and I know what my colleagues position is on it but I need to make up my own mind. I am interested to know how I can use to for other parts of my business.”

San Altman “People talk about how much energy it takes to train an AI model – but it also takes a lot of energy to train a human...It takes about 20 years of life – and all the food you consume during that time – before you become smart.” Despite that defense, he said that the public assessment of AI’s energy consumption was “fair”, adding: “We need to move towards nuclear or wind and solar very quickly.”
<https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2026/feb/23/sam-altman-openai-energy-use-datacenters>

Why did the studio pick this one?

West is home to LA media scene and SF home to AI scene. Both scenes also, at least on the individual consumerism level, highly favor ecologically responsible luxury goods and services.

Taste-washing is the new green-washing but different because it comes after work that is not as easy to commodify as code, it comes after our brain and our aesthetic resistance. Its also reminiscent of Fashwave which was a case of a far-right project successfully wearing a left-or-neutral-coded aesthetic.

Greg Brockman (OpenAI President): "Taste is a new core skill."

Paul Graham (Y Combinator): in an AI age "taste will become even more important."

Koen Bok (Framer founder): those with "great taste" will build the next great products.

Anthropic spokesperson to Axios (April 2026), describing Claude Opus 4.7: outputs "align better with what an experienced practitioner in that domain would consider great work" — i.e., the company is now marketing taste as a model capability.

In your roles within Song and DDP, how does it impact your work or your clients?

Just yesterday I used AI to make a video for a fashion brand whose consumers value ecology, look like it was hand crafted with felt. I wasn’t sure how I felt.

Subscription Fatigue — Ownership Renaissance

Accenture Federal Team / Washington DC

The Premise

Consumers are rejecting the role of perpetual digital tenants. In response to rising costs, forced obsolescence, and eroding trust in subscription models, a clear preference for tangible ownership has emerged.

This movement champions perpetual licenses, self-hosted media, and physical formats to ensure lasting control and value.

Why is this important?

This trend is rooted in a significant erosion of consumer trust, directly linked to the financial model of recurring subscriptions. The steady, incremental price increases—or "price creep"—common to these services are no longer being passively accepted. This combination of financial pressure and loss of trust is altering consumer behavior.

We are observing a strategic disengagement from platform lock-in manifesting in several ways: microtransactions for pay-for-use purchases, the adoption of short-term or "churn-and-return" subscription habits, a measurable resurgence in physical media sales, and the exploration of custom-built or open-source software solutions.

Beyond immediate financial considerations, this trend signals a growing unease with the disintegration of private property in the digital sphere. The subscription model fundamentally alters the concept of ownership. When access to entertainment, software, or even physical products is contingent on recurring payments, the user's control is conditional. The revocation of a license or the closure of an account can dissolve a user's digital footprint, raising fundamental questions about the stability and rights associated with digital assets in a market economy.

What is the core conflict / opportunity?

The original promise of subscriptions was convenience, control, and choice. Fast forward to 2027, consumers feel overwhelmed with managing multiple recurring payments “stacks” across almost all aspects of their lives.

Subscriptions ask customers to maintain an ongoing relationship with dozens of companies simultaneously where the odds are stacked in their favor. When consumers pay for a subscription, they don’t actually own anything; instead, they pay for the right to use something for only a period of time that the owning party determines. An appetite for ownership is a desire for fewer dependencies and more control on where consumers spend their hard-earned money.

Key statistics / quotes / evidence (from within your country)

1. Subscription Fatigue is a Documented Economic Trend Driven by Price Hikes.

The core financial driver of this trend is "subscription fatigue," a recognized market phenomenon where consumers, facing relentless price increases, are actively canceling services. This isn't anecdotal; it's a pattern confirmed by market events and financial analysis.

For example, major streaming services like Netflix continue to increase prices on core plans [1], leading directly to reports of widespread consumer cancellations as households re-evaluate their budgets [2]. The issue is so significant that it is being tracked as a mainstream economic trend [3] and has expanded beyond media to the broader service economy, where "fee backlash" against delivery apps may lead to federal review [4].

2. A Measurable Generational Shift Towards Physical and Analog Ownership.

The backlash against digital renting is fueling a direct and measurable return to physical media, particularly among younger demographics. Gen Z, a cohort that grew up with streaming, is now actively seeking out and purchasing physical media like DVDs and Blu-rays. This behavior is explicitly linked to "subscription economy burnout" and a desire to own tangible assets [5] [6]. This is not nostalgia; it is a conscious consumer choice for permanence, evidenced by press and market reports confirming a renewed interest in owning physical media as a direct alternative to the limitations of streaming [7].

Key statistics / quotes / evidence (continued)

3. Platform Instability and Lack of Control Reinforce the Need for Personal Archives.

Beyond cost, the trend is reinforced by a fundamental lack of control and permanence on subscription platforms. Incidents like data leaks or the potential for a user's curated library to be compromised highlight the fragility of "rented" digital collections [8]. This instability validates the core motivation behind the self-hosting community (Plex, Jellyfin), which seeks to establish "digital sovereignty." [9] Consumers are moving to create their own archives not just to avoid fees, but to ensure their access to content cannot be revoked, altered, or lost by a third-party provider.

4. Ownership-Based Alternatives Challenge Software Subscriptions. Growing dissatisfaction with costly software subscriptions has sparked strong competition from companies offering perpetual licenses. Creative industry rivals like DaVinci Resolve, Procreate, and Affinity now provide buy-once, own-forever options, making independence from Adobe’s subscription model increasingly realistic. [10]

Why did the studio pick this one?

This trend sparked multiple conversations across the three sessions we hosted for trend gathering. Many participants shared stories about how subscriptions and the original conveniences they bring had been replaced by higher prices, limited services, and the risk of losing access at any time.

In your roles within Song and DDP, how does it impact your work or your clients (or could)?

This trend impacted the Accenture Federal Team when Invision shut down services in 2024, requiring a lengthy search to secure a replacement with Figma. (No small feat to get government approval to use a new tool) and a race to keep from losing years of project work trapped in the Invision Cloud.

As consumers, we feel this personally through the many subscriptions we utilize (Spotify, Adobe Creative Cloud, Car infotainment subscriptions, etc.) that limit their long-term use, repairability, and access to old data that risks being trapped through end of life or planned obsolescence.

Individuals > Institutions — The “Authenticity Premium”

Accenture Federal Team / Washington DC

The Premise

Consumers increasingly value individual voices over legacy institutions, especially as those institutions lay off seasoned, trusted voices and the U.S. government pressures and challenges the legitimacy of legacy media outlets.

Creator-led channels are becoming primary discovery and learning outlets while the traditional mass media that previous generations turned to are losing trust and attention.

Why is this important?

The old system of legitimacy — where institutional prestige and inside relationships became the gatekeepers of knowledge — has collapsed. For example, 4 out of 10 U.S. adults now rely on individuals without formal medical backgrounds for advice or to explain things in a more personal way. The effect feels more immediate and lower barrier to achieve.

Policy, science, and social spaces are experiencing similar effects. Popular podcasters, and YouTube creators reach the same audience that major news networks compete for, with the accessibility of their shows on multiple streaming platforms.

Podcasters and influencers form relationships around lifestyles that their audience are inherently interested in, representing a voice that feels more authentic and relatable.

What is the core conflict / opportunity?

Here’s where it gets complex. Trust is being built on parasocial relationships – relationships influence a company’s perceived level of trustworthiness. But this trust can easily be misleading; it doesn’t take someone knowledgeable in the topic of interest to speak, just that they speak with confidence consistency and in plain language.

Key statistics / quotes / evidence (from within your country)

1. The Foundational Collapse of Institutional Trust: The foundation of this trend is a historic and measurable collapse of public trust in legacy media. Data from Gallup shows that trust in mass media has fallen to its second lowest point on record [\[1\]](#), a sentiment echoed by extensive research from the Pew Research Center tracking the decades-long decline in public trust in government and media institutions. [\[2\]](#) [\[3\]](#) This widespread distrust is not monolithic; it is particularly pronounced among younger generations and is fueled by a complex set of factors that have been developing for over a decade. [\[4\]](#) [\[5\]](#)

2. The Rise of the Individual as a Credible Alternative: This trust vacuum is being filled by a new class of individual creators. Outlets and academic institutions now explicitly document the "rise of influencers" and "citizen journalism" as a direct consequence of the "fall of journalism" [\[6\]](#). As a result, creator-led platforms like YouTube are no longer just for entertainment; they are functioning as primary "newsrooms" for a growing audience, with individual creators tackling complex topics and, in some cases, producing work that rivals that of legacy news organizations [\[7\]](#) [\[8\]](#) [\[9\]](#) This has elevated the "influencer" to a powerful and legitimate new voice in the public sphere [\[10\]](#).

3. A Proven Model for Influence and a Generational Shift: This is not a passing fad but a fundamental realignment, driven by the media consumption habits of Gen Z, who are demonstrably more likely to trust and engage with individual creators over faceless institutions [\[11\]](#). The power of this direct-to-audience model is being proven in the political arena, where individuals are using creator-native formats to bypass traditional campaign structures and build viral movements, demonstrating a new path to influence and power that legacy organizations are now trying to replicate [\[10\]](#)[\[11\]](#).

Key statistics / quotes / evidence (continued)

1. “The Trust Paradox: Why People Prefer Human Judgment Even as They Rely More on AI”

People trust human judgment more than AI systems because they worry about mistakes, lack of transparency [\[12\]](#), and unreliable information, which reinforces the belief that human oversight is more accountable [\[13\]](#). Even so, many people, and particularly teens, are turning to AI and chatbots for everything from advice and help with schoolwork to companionship.[\[14\]](#)

This trend has raised concerns among parents and advocates [\[15\]](#). There is a risk that as users become accustomed to the sycophantic nature of AI, they may lose the coping skills required to deal with difficult situations. [\[16\]](#)

This reveals a central paradox: a simultaneous public mistrust of AI for making important decisions while an increasing reliance on it for guidance and support. As AI usage increases and threatens to “flatten” how people communicate into a uniform, machine-like style [\[17\]](#), authentic, accountable human voices will matter more than ever.

Why did the studio pick this one?

For our government clients there’s opportunity to analyze how trust is built in this new decentralized media ecosystem that thrives on authenticity, direct engagement, and speaking with a clear human voice that connects with the right audience. And in the age of AI, authenticity stands out more than ever.

In your roles within Song and DDP, how does it impact your work or your clients (or could)?

For our clients, there is an opportunity for them to meet their customers where they are in more specific, niche, and authentic communication channels.

Demise of the monoculture

TREND 1 | US South

Abstract

There has been a lot written about the shattering of the consensus reality. That plays out in myriad ways, but a critical part is the social and cultural atomization created. In a culture where a shared understanding of reality is absent as the load-bearing pillar of a monoculture, there is a tangible real-world loss of community and disconnection from a true popular culture; Subcultures have filled this gap.

The constellation of media spaces, both social, alt, and traditional, have become so plentiful and so catered that individuals can find and connect with incredibly niche subcultures. Subcultures have always existed for people seeking a community that resonates more with their interests and values, but those spaces have been divergent aberrations from monoculture. Subcultures are now the default spaces.

Localized incarnations

Niche cultural events

In any large metro there has been an explosion in hyper-niche community and cultural events. What was once, more or less, one art scene is now a vast constellation of art directed at very specific audiences. It was once easy to be plugged into almost all art and cultural events and spaces.

Obscured entry points

Hobbies and special interest have also exploded as individuals feel the hole left by the absence of community. On any given weekend, there are innumerable hobby meetups that are completely inaccessible to those outside of an established community.

Death of the gatekeeper

Niche spaces that were once zealously guarded by the zealots of the subculture eager to maintain the intentional distance from the monoculture applied social pressure to keep out those seen as interlopers. With the dissolution of the monoculture and its replacement with subcultures as the default norm, this social pressure mechanism has reversed; gatekeepers are social pariahs.

Business and design implications

Niche targeting

Reaching broad swaths of the population is now incredibly difficult, products and services that attempt to are largely regarded with contempt as being out of touch or normie. Communications strategies of the future will have to learn how to gain entry to niche spaces and find messaging that can resonate with subsets or groupings of subsets of the broader population. Savvy, effective communicators will be able authentically gain access to these niche communities.

Design for narrower swaths of tastes

Gone are the days of sleek, minimalist, baohaus design aesthetics and methodologies which embrace a “correct” way to design. Niche communities have niche tastes and ultraspecialized psychologies and philosophies. To the extent it was ever true, there are no universal laws of usability and desirability anymore.

Neu-urbanism and agrario-curiosity

TREND 2 | US South

Abstract

The vibrant hyper modern utopian urban centers promised in the beautifully designed architectural models World's Fairs past have never materialized. While there is still an overarching trend of urbanization, there is the dialectical truth that the current urbanized population is dissatisfied with urban life.

The juxtaposition of a “back-to-nature” cultural zeitgeist and a desire to be in dense urban environments has created unexpected results. There is a fixation on the concept of walkable “15-minute cities” and insular neighborhoods that anchor the residents in a community. There is also a desire for a greater connection to the natural world. The gardening industry has seen huge growth after decades of slump. In a society so divorced from natural living, people want it all. They want to live in a large diverse space that offers the cultural variety that makes city-life interesting, at the same time they want a connection to a community and to the Earth.

The dream of a slick techno future is out of favor and a world in which the reality of our technological urban world can coexist with living a more naturally human life.

Localized incarnations

Community and home gardens

In the last 10 years community gardens have become vastly more numerous. Every neighborhood now has a community garden that is never in a deficit of volunteers. As you travel through Atlanta the number of raised vegetable gardens featured prominently in front yards is inescapable. There have been dozens of boutique house-plant shops that have popped up in virtually every neighborhood offering a “premium” gardening experience.

Insulation of neighborhoods

Atlanta, and the US writ large, have notoriously bad transit infrastructure due to decades of over indexing on the personal vehicle and extensive lobbying by the automotive industry at the expense of good mass transit. Atlanta has added 70,000/year for the last 10 years. Individual car transport is no longer tenable. As a result, Atlanta has formed a network of small neighborhoods with “downtowns.” This has always been a feature of Atlanta’s city planning, but what is new is the investment in these spaces. Every in-town neighborhood is now largely self-contained with its own grocery stores, pharmacies, restaurants, health care, dry cleaners, etc. The cross-town travel so common 15 years ago is largely unnecessary in the day-to-day life of most residents.

Business and design implications

Investment opportunities

There is a genuine market demand for investment in hyper-localized areas. Organizations that can figure out how to serve the needs and wants of small populations will see growth.

Bold visions of the future

Organizations that will read the cultural temperature in the room and begin to adjust their vision for the future and company purpose to project a future where technology, urbanism, and decentralized access to critical resources, and living in balance with nature will win trust and will win business.

The aesthetics and design philosophy of community-based techno-agrarianism

Nowhere is the changing desires of a vision of the future better exemplified than the rise of the “solar punk” aesthetic. First coming in gaming spaces, this art and design style is flourishing. It feels honest and harmonious. Its permutations can be found in every aspect of design. In physical spaces it manifests as earthy desaturated colors, natural and organic textures, and material honesty (the practice of not disguising one physical material as another. E.g., plastics that mimic wood). Organizations that embrace this change of the slick and smooth minimalism of the 2010s will succeed.

Technocratic backlash and the data center war

TREND 3 | US South

Abstract

The populations of the Americas and Western Europe are becoming increasingly hostile to what feels like a runaway unaccountable tech industry. Poor behavior by tech investors have soured people to tech firms and have made them suspicious of their intentions. The most broad-coalition consensus is that data-centers and battery production facilities are undesirable. In every area news can be found of hastily planned data center builds that are wildly unpopular due to their disregard of their effects on the communities around them and occasional outright fraud or regulatory breaches committed by these firms.

Localized incarnations

Grassroots rejection of data centers

In every metro Atlanta county there are currently planned data centers and intense fighting against them. Atlanta has quick access to many of the necessary natural and logistical infrastructure necessary for these data centers. Residents are finding out data centers make bad neighbors; they are hot, creating microclimates around them, strain the power grid, strain the water table, and provide only a tiny amount permanent jobs, and due to tax deals contribute very little to the local tax base.

Examples:

proposed \$5 billion Rivian factory near Atlanta has faced intense local resistance, stalling, and legal battles, resulting in a paused project after over \$200 million in state funds were already spent on site preparation. Residents cite environmental concerns (groundwater impact), disruption of rural character, and lack of transparency.

DeKalb County (Ellenwood): Residents and activists have protested a proposed 1-million-square-foot data center, raising alarms about environmental impact and high-volume water usage. A "pause" on new data center developments was extended until June 23, 2026, to evaluate these impacts.

Southwest Atlanta: In April 2026, a community meeting led to a 105–87 vote rejecting a proposed data center, with residents citing concerns over the strain on resources and a desire for community-focused development rather than industrial expansion.

Tech misbehavior souring public trust

Over the last decade there have been countless public scandals at the conduct of developers; from shady land swaps, misappropriated public funding, outright knowingly breaching environmental protections, and innumerable accusations of fraud and corruption. Trust in tech firms and especially private equity has cratered.

Examples:

DeKalb County exchanged 40 acres of Intrenchment Creek Park (ICP) for 53 acres of land owned by then-Blackhall Studios (now Shadowbox Studios) owner Ryan Millsap. Failed Promises: The developer failed to complete the promised expansion of the movie studio and did not deliver on promised workforce development or specific park improvements (\$1.5 million) to the new location. Data Center Threat: Reports suggest the exchanged parkland is being considered for a data center development rather than the promised studio expansion.

QTS campus, managed by Blackstone, used 29+ million gallons over a period of 4 to 15 months, according to differing reports. The Cause: Two industrial-scale water hookups were discovered; one was installed without utility knowledge, and the other was not linked to the company’s billing account.

Business and design implications

Reputation and trust rehab

For firms that want to maintain a sustainable relationship with the public and with their customers, tech and development firms must engage in conspicuous transparency and adherence to ecological and tax regulations.

Clear and cogent messaging

It is critical at this moment for firms to make public, clear, and cogent arguments for the necessity of their resource consumption. It will no longer be enough to say, “we need it for progress.” They must explain what the end goal of the progress is and how it will benefit the public good.

Design by collaboration

Design methodologies must focus on intense and direct collaboration with the public and the end consumer. The design language needs to be a dialog between organization and the public. Design aesthetics and tone should be less sleek and polished, it should show humanity, and it should include idiosyncrasies and “mistakes.”

Clocking Out of AI

USA - Midwest

The Premise

A new boundary is forming between the AI-saturated workplace and the rest of life. Adoption is rising sharply on one side of that line and falling on the other; people are introducing friction and spending real money to keep the line clear.

AI is becoming workwear: what you put on for the office, not what you wear to be yourself.

Why is this important?

The dominant narrative is a single adoption curve going up, and the numbers at work back it: half of US workers now use AI in their role (Gallup, Feb 2026), and frequent white-collar use jumped 12 points to 27% in a single year. The Midwest shows there are actually two curves: one steep at work, one flat or declining at home.

What people choose to do for themselves is increasingly defined as *the opposite* of what they do for their employer, and that gap is becoming a real consumer category.

What is the core conflict / opportunity?

AI adoption **at work** is delivering measurable productivity gains.

Meanwhile, consumer trust in AI in **personal/intimate contexts** is collapsing, and the rejection is becoming organized and economic; the "AI ick" is now a culturally legible category. The same people rejecting AI at home are using it daily at work.

Opportunity: recognize that AI isn't a single product strategy- it's context-dependent.

Key statistics / quotes / evidence

- Friction economy is going mainstream ([Light Phone III launches developer SDK](#), [Tin Can hits cultural milestone](#), [Brick sees 600% YoY download surge](#))
- Analog hobbies and craft as the new luxury ([Film order volumes up 127% globally since 2020](#), [Camera store thriving](#), [Penguin Foot Pottery](#) is consistently waitlisted)
- "Made by humans" becoming a premium positioning across industries ([iHeartMedia's "guaranteed human" tagline](#), ["made by humans" as the new premium label](#))
- AI products facing organized public rejection ([#QuitGPT campaign hits 700,000 pledges](#), [Instacart's algorithmic-pricing backlash](#), [Pinterest adds AI-slop filters after user backlash](#))
- The "AI ick" enters mainstream language ([Zara Larsson fans riot over AI reposting](#), [Merriam-Webster names "slop" 2025 Word of the Year](#))

Why did the studio pick this one?

The same observation kept surfacing across our Midwest colleagues, in different forms: 'Bricking', ceramics studios, the rise of "AI ick," **people quietly walling AI out of their personal lives even as they adopt it at work.**

It builds on "Finding Neo" (2026) by showing AI resistance moving from philosophical to behavioral. The Midwest is showing two curves, on the same person, and the gap between them is where a lot of consumer behavior now lives.

In your roles within Song and DDP, how does it impact your work or your clients?

- Companies should figure out which customer moments need to feel human and which can quietly automate; treat AI as a design choice, not a default
 - Let users turn it off in personal moments (cards, gifts, photos, messages) and keep it in functional ones (search, scheduling)
- Audit the AI features no one asked for. Autocomplete, chatbots, generated suggestions - in some categories, they're making the experience worse.
- Don't assume employees love AI at work just because they're using it
 - Internal tools and change programs should acknowledge the gap between mandate and preference

Copy-Paste Cities

USA - Midwest

The Premise

The most-hyped openings of 2026 aren't local — they're East Coast or LA brands deploying their signature concept into Chicago. Beyond commerce, the physical bones of Midwest cities are starting to look interchangeable: the same autonomous vehicles, the same delivery robots, the same glass-tower developments, the same commodified public spaces.

Cities are converging on a shared template - the same restaurants, the same aesthetic, the same infrastructure - and **the people who live in them are starting to ask what it costs to live somewhere that could be anywhere.**

Why is this important?

The flattening of cities isn't new, but the *awareness* of it is. People can now name what's happening to their neighborhoods as it happens, and they're starting to act on it. **The cost is also becoming literal:** Chicago's median home price has climbed 45% since 2019 to \$385,000, with rents pushing \$2,000/month and inventory shrinking.

"Good Vibrations" (2026) told us hyperlocal third spaces were the antidote to digital flattening. The Midwest is showing us **hyperlocal can be mass-produced too**; the social, civic, and emotional cost of that convergence is becoming visible in how people choose to live, leave, and push back.

What is the core conflict / opportunity?

Convergence delivers things people genuinely want: better restaurants, more amenities, more capital flowing in. But it costs something quieter: the specificity that made a place worth choosing.

People can now feel both sides of that trade at once, and they're trying to decide what they're willing to pay for what.

Key statistics / quotes / evidence

- Chicago restaurants self-cloning across neighborhoods ([Pizza Lobo expansion](#), [Heisler Hospitality's portfolio playbook across Chicago](#))
- National brands using Chicago as a tour stop ([PopUp Bagels opens with 2.5-hour lines](#), [D.C.'s Call Your Mother](#), [LA's Erewhon](#))
- The same aesthetic showing up everywhere ([Chicago Sun-Times calls 2025's restaurant year "conceptually risk-averse"](#))
- Delivery robots and robotaxis arrive; residents push back ([Waymo begins mapping Chicago](#), [Coco and Serve robots smash CTA bus shelters](#), [alderman bans delivery robots after opposition](#))
- Public space turning into pay-to-experience ([Chicago Riverwalk concession RFP](#), [Corp Partnership Opportunities at Millennium Park](#))
- Civic engagement in many forms (75,000+ at Chicago's "No Kings" rally, [felt loss of place](#), [art studios open for free sign-making](#))
- Housing pricing out the people who built the city ([Chicago rents hit ~\\$2,000/month as construction stalls](#), [Woodlawn home prices up 4.6x since Obama Center announcement](#), [with widespread displacement](#))

Why did the studio pick this one?

The convergence of cities is something Chicago is experiencing in real time, and our D&DP colleagues surfaced it from many directions: restaurant chains masquerading as indies, the same coffee aesthetic in every city, robotaxis arriving on a schedule no one agreed to.

It's the counterpoint to "Good Vibrations" (2026): what happens when hyperlocal itself becomes a template? What makes this distinctive is the cost of that convergence is finally becoming visible to the people paying it; residents are pushing back through closed networks, ward-level action, and first-time civic engagement.

In your roles within Song and DDP, how does it impact your work or your clients?

- Specificity as the new differentiation: as venture-backed templates flood every category, the brands that feel “uncopyable” will win
- People are rebuilding trust through closed networks. Open algorithms are losing ground to vouched, invitation-based, friend-of-a-friend systems; loyalty, referrals, and community features should reflect this
- The same UI patterns, the same brand systems, the same "elevated indie" look show up everywhere now. Audit where consistency is helping the customer and where it's just making you forgettable.